Israeli election outlook

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The Israeli election is too close to call, with the two main blocs polling in the low-to-mid-50 Knesset seats; the most likely outcome is an inconclusive vote leading to a repeat election, with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu remaining as caretaker for several months.
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A minority government led by former Israeli Defense Forces chief of staff Gadi Eisenkot, with passive Arab party support, is assessed at nearly even odds—the clearest path to replacing Netanyahu.
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President Donald Trump has quietly distanced himself from Netanyahu, likely calculating that a new Israeli government would be more useful for advancing his Gaza plan, Saudi normalization, and Abraham Accords expansion.

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Speakers:

Ambassador Daniel Shapiro, Distinguished Fellow, Atlantic Council; former Deputy Assistant Secretary of Defense for the Middle East; former U.S. Ambassador to Israel;

Firas Maksad, Managing Director, Middle East and North Africa, Eurasia Group (moderator)

Electoral Landscape: A Four-Way Split With No Clear Path to 61.

The two main political blocs in Israeli politics are currently polling in the low-to-mid-50 seats—short of the 61 seats needed for a majority in the 120-seat Knesset.

Ambassador Dan Shapiro outlined four scenarios:

1.

Netanyahu forms a government (10%). His current coalition holds 61+ seats but is polling in the low-to-mid-50s for the upcoming vote. All opposition parties have pledged categorically not to support him, and any defection would be politically suicidal for the party involved.

2.

Opposition minority government (40% probability). An Eisenkot-led coalition receives passive support or abstentions from one or more Arab parties (with the Arab bloc averaging 12-13 seats in current polls), winning a confidence vote without formally including Arab parties in the cabinet. Rare and unstable, but viable.

3.

Inconclusive result and repeat election (45% probability). Neither bloc can form a government through two sequential six-week coalition-building windows. Netanyahu remains caretaker—with reduced but non-zero authority, particularly on national security. Israel went through four such cycles between 2019–2021; a repeat is plausible, potentially landing a new election around March.

4.

National unity government (5% probability). Broad public support exists, but any configuration that keeps Netanyahu as prime minister is a non-starter for the opposition. A rotation with Netanyahu as junior partner is legally complicated: under Israeli law, an indicted official cannot hold any ministerial portfolio other than prime minister, requiring either a legal change or a pardon.

Key Turnout Variables to Watch on Election Night

Results may take days to clarify. Shapiro flagged five specific indicators:

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Threshold parties on the right: Amcha Yisrael (recently polling below the 3.25% electoral threshold after an initial surge to 5–6 seats) and Religious Zionism (Smotrich's party, also flirting with falling below threshold). Wasted votes on the right benefit the opposition.

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The Reservists Party (Yoaz Hendel, currently just above threshold): a potential swing party uncomfortable with both Arab inclusion and ultra-Orthodox exemptions—could go either direction.

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Arab sector turnout: Historically as low as ~50% versus mid-70s nationally. A surge would benefit the anti-Netanyahu bloc.

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Ultra-Orthodox turnout: Some dissatisfaction over failure to codify a permanent conscription exemption may depress their numbers.

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Swing Likud voters: Security-minded former Netanyahu voters, alienated by a lack of 7 October accountability as well as corruption charges, represent only ~150,000–180,000 voters—but enough to move 3-4 seats. Recent polls suggest some may be drifting back to Likud.

"October Surprise": Low Probability, Trump-Constrained

Shapiro assessed the probability of a pre-election Israeli military strike—against Iran, Lebanon, or Yemen—as low and declining. The key constraint is Washington. Trump has signaled he does not want to reignite regional conflict before the US midterms, and Shapiro noted IDF Chief of Staff Eyal Zamir has reportedly told American officials that a major conflict could force postponement of Israel's elections—an argument Zamir is actively deploying to restrain escalation.

Yemen is the most plausible scenario given Saudi-Houthi fighting and reported Israeli-Gulf coordination, but the Houthis have not attacked Israel in the current period and are not striking its Red Sea shipping as they did in 2023–2025 period. Shapiro's bottom line: "My money is on not seeing that happen."

What Likely Changes—and What Doesn't—Under a Different Government

Both blocs are right of center and broadly aligned on the new security doctrine of maintaining buffer zones in Gaza, Lebanon, and Syria, and on preemptive posture toward Iran. Shapiro cautioned against overstating the difference. That said, he identified several areas of meaningful divergence under an opposition-led government:

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West Bank settler violence: All opposition parties have committed to using Shin Bet, police, and the military to shut down Jewish extremist attacks on Palestinians—something the current government, under far-right National Security Minister Itamar Ben-Gvir and Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich, has been unwilling rather than unable to do.
*
Palestinian Authority relations: An opposition government would likely resume transfer of customs revenues withheld from the PA and treat the PA as a flawed but functional partner rather than an entity to be collapsed.
*
Settlement expansion: The E1 corridor expansion—which would impede contiguous Palestinian territory—would likely be paused. Annexation rhetoric would recede.
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Gaza 20-point plan: The opposition is more likely to be seen as trying to implement Trump's framework (disarmament, reconstruction, technocratic Palestinian leadership, international stabilization force, and a "credible pathway" to a Palestinian state per Point 19), whereas the current government is largely perceived as obstructing it absent full Hamas disarmament.

Trump's Quiet Distancing From Netanyahu

Shapiro drew a notable inference from Trump's behavior over the past three months: fewer phone calls, no visit to Israel, no endorsement despite repeated direct questions, and Trump's absence during Netanyahu's UN General Assembly visit (Trump was in Washington meeting Xi Jinping).

Two explanations were put forward: Trump avoids backing potential losers, and—more significantly—Trump's team understands that his remaining agenda (Gaza plan, Saudi normalization, Abraham Accords expansion) is harder to execute with Netanyahu given the controversies and likely coalition partners Ben Gvir and Smotrich. Shapiro stopped short of calling this an active preference for the opposition, but described it as a deliberate non-endorsement.

Syria and Lebanon: Diplomatic Openings Under New Leadership

Even the current Netanyahu government came close to a security arrangement with Syrian President Ahmad al-Shara—requiring Israeli withdrawal from its post-Assad buffer zone, Syrian assurances on border security and protection of the Druze minority, and limits on Turkish presence in Syria. Shapiro described that deal as "eminently reachable" and assessed that an Eisenkot-led government would move quickly to close it, partly to signal flexibility to Trump and Arab partners.

On Lebanon, Shapiro was more cautious: Any Israeli government will remain vigilant on Hezbollah's residual capability and will not compromise on disarmament, though a different government might extend more time to Beirut to comply.

Key Watch Items

1.
Threshold party performance on election night—particularly Amcha Yisrael and Religious Zionism falling below 3.25%, which would shift the seat distribution materially toward the opposition.
2.
Arab sector and ultra-Orthodox turnout—deviations from historical patterns in either community could be decisive given the narrow margins.
3.
Knesset speaker vote—within days of the election, a potential opposition majority may attempt to seize the legislative agenda before a government is formed, risking a constitutional crisis like 2020.
4.
Trump's posture toward coalition formation—whether he actively facilitates or discourages a unity government, a pardon for Netanyahu, or a particular coalition outcome.
5.
IDF Chief of Staff Zamir's operational influence—his reported resistance to pre-election military escalation is a key stabilizing variable; watch for any shift in his posture or standing.
6.
Syria deal progress—early signals from a new government on willingness to finalize a security arrangement with Damascus would be a leading indicator of broader regional diplomatic direction.

What Clients Are Asking

Probability of another election: Shapiro assessed this as nearly even odds—neither bloc can currently reach 61 seats, and the sequential coalition-formation process (up to six weeks per attempt) could exhaust both options and trigger a new vote, potentially around March 2027.

How different would an Eisenkot government be on security? The substantive security doctrine—buffer zones, Iran preemption posture—is broadly shared across the spectrum. The more meaningful differences are on West Bank settler violence enforcement, PA relations, settlement expansion, and willingness to engage Trump's Gaza framework.

Why can't Netanyahu serve as a minister in a unity government? Israeli law bars indicted officials from all ministerial positions except prime minister. Any non-prime-ministerial role in a unity rotation would require either a legal change or a pardon—adding significant complexity to the unity government scenario.

Arab party inclusion: Is it viable post-October 7? Shapiro argued that in the moment of truth, if the math supports it, opposition parties are more likely than not to accept passive Arab support for a minority government—particularly from the Ra’am party, given its inclusion of a Jewish former senior law enforcement official on its list and its stated focus on community-level crime, not national identity politics.

Trump's role in the outcome: Trump has not endorsed Netanyahu and shows no sign of doing so. Shapiro's read is that Trump calculates his remaining second-term agenda is better served by a new

Israeli government—and that he has enough influence over Israeli military escalation decisions to keep the region quiet through the election.

Please note that while this AI-generated summary has been checked for accuracy against the source material, it may not capture every nuance or qualifier from the discussion. The full transcript or audio should be consulted for complete context.

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